

Chapter 11: Expansion and Sectional Crisis

In the 1820s and 1830s the thirst for westward expansion was stemmed by the acquisition of Florida and Louisiana, however in the 1840s the thirst began anew. However as expansion was considered so was the possibility of slavery being permitted in the new territories.

There were many reasons for the new want in expansion. One of these was the peoples thirst for the large, boundless tracts of land that lay just outside the countries border. Fur trappers had been blazing trails, searching for passes over the mountains and into the far west. They brought publicity to the area beyond the Great American Desert. Another reason was the want for more trade with the orient, that they assumed was more easily accessible from the west. The third reason was the sudden reflux of fear of foreign intervention along the nations borders. Another thing that greatly strengthened this was the doctrine of Manifest Destiny, which stated it was Americas destiny to extend the area of freedom.

One of the first areas in expansion was Texas. The Mexicans had won their freedom and welcomed any Americans that wanted to submit to its laws and jurisdiction. However they would not sell Texas, a successful Texas promoter was Stephen F Austin, he obtained a grant from Mexico and started a thriving colony on the banks of the Brazos river. However Americans had no intention of submitting to the Mexicans. In 1830 the Mexican govt. banned further immigration and importation of slaves, and put heavy duties on American goods, they sent troops to enforce the laws. The Texans had no choice but revolution, in 1836 they declared their independence. The new Republic of Texas drafted a constitution, however most Texans rallied for annexation. Their president, Houston, began negotiations with Washington for recognition and annexation. Whigs believed that annexation would cause war with Mexico, and Texas became a challenge to abolishing slavery, therefore both President Jackson and Van Buren did not go along with annexation. So in 1838 Texas turned to Europe for recognition, the British liked this, seeing Texas as a buffer to the US and a challenge to the cotton market. This caused president Tyler to move for annexation, his secretary of state, John C. Calhoun got the treaty, and submitted it to the senate. However Calhoun also sent a note to England about Texas, defending slavery as good, this made the abolitionists in the senate mad, they voted against annexation and it was again delayed.

Americans took claim to the Oregon area, but so did the British. The Americans based fur companies along the Columbia river, which was found by Lewis and Clark. However the British's Sir Francis Drake supposedly discovered the coast of Oregon in 1579. Other British explorers had visited it in the past also they claimed. Since no one could decide on who had rights to the land, they decided in 1818 to leave the land "free and open" for 10 years. In 1827 it was extended indefinitely. For a while Americans had no interest in Oregon leaving it to the fur traders. Then in 1833 word got to the east that Oregon Indians wanted instruction in the Christian faith. While this note had little substance to it the church sent Reverend Jason Lee to establish a mission. The religious aspect did not go well, however word got to the east about Oregons great climate and soil. Word spread and people caught "Oregon Fever," which caused a steady trickle to travel the Oregon trail and overtake Oregon from the British.

California was another Mexican area where Manifest Destiny beckoned Americans. To strengthen the control over California, friars were sent to establish missions along the coast. The missions were successful as agricultural enterprises. Other than that the only American contacts with California were ships stopping in for supplies or trade, and stranded sailors. Thomas O. Larkin was one of the few traders that went to California, he established flourishing trade and caused some groups to travel from Oregon to California, there were about 700 Americans in California as of 1845.

Another group that went west with Manifest Destiny were the Mormons, looking to escape jurisdiction of the US. They went west, established towns and irrigation that made them thrive, they later formed Utah.

The Election of 1844 was influenced by the issues of the panic of 1837 and the annexation of Texas. The Whigs selected Henry Clay, and took a stand avoiding the question of Texas. The Democrats chose James K Polk of Tennessee who was committed to western expansion and immediate annexation of Texas. Polk was a strong individual and followed the Jacksonian principals. Once elected Polk favored and passed a low revenue tariff, which angered the Northern Protectionists and pleased the South. The most important area of the Polk administration was expansion. Polk got Texas to annexed, and then turned to Oregon. Americans and British hadn't settled on a line of division yet, Polk offered to divide at the 49th parallel, but it was rejected, from then on policy changed to All or None. However Britain didn't want to fight over it, and suggested division at the 49th, while still retaining all of Vancouver Island and navigation rights to the Columbia, this was accepted and a treaty signed.

In the mean time there were problems with the Mexicans that led to war. Americans were mad over the Mexican Govt. not settling claims for compensation, and Mexican patriots were mad over the annexation of Texas. However Polk had in his mind the acquisition of New Mexico and California. Polk realized that there was little chance of Mexico giving up the lands peacefully, and he sent John Slidell to attempt to buy the territories. Mexican nationalists found out about Slidell's purpose and were quite furious, his mission failed and Polk drafted a war message to Congress, then 25 Mexican soldiers crossed the border and killed or wounded 16 Americans, this was sent to congress and war was declared. It took 3 US military campaigns until the Mexicans surrendered. Nicholas P. Trist was sent to negotiate, and although he was recalled to Washington before negotiations he stayed there and signed the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo, it accepted California, New Mexico, the Rio Grande, and all claims from Americans against Mexico for \$15 million.

Slavery was again an issue as the Wilmot Proviso proved, it stated that slaves shall not exist in American territory. It twice failed in the Senate. In fact a bill creating Oregon territory did not pass because it stated no slavery. Calhoun led a group of pro slavery southerners to say that territories were property of the whole nation, therefore anyone could migrate their with their property, including slaves, therefore Congress could not abolish slavery in those areas. From these two extremes "popular sovereignty" was formed, as an intermediate doctrine. The new territories were left without govt.'s. and the question was thrown into the election of 1848. Democrats chose Lewis Cass, who took the new intermediate doctrine to appease as many as possible. Whigs selected Zachary Taylor, a war hero, to avoid controversy they wrote no platform. In the end Taylor was elected by a slim amount. As Taylor took control the territories were being led by army officials that reported to the president, this angered settlers. Then gold was discovered in California, and a surge of "49ers" arrived to mine. Without a civil govt. and a pop. of over 100,000 it was chaos. Taylor told Calif and New Mex to form constitutions. and apply for statehood, California did so and drafted a constitution banning slavery, and were made a state in 1849. In the mean time, Texas and New Mexico were nearly at war over their shared border. To settle Calhoun submitted a series of resolutions to the congress, who debated them for 7 months, then another large debate took place where Calhoun and Webster both spoke. It resulted in the Compromise of 1850, it made Calif. a free state, and sealed the Texas border, and Utah and NM territories with no slave restrictions. No one was really satisfied with the compromise. However, they dealt with it, and congress men signed a pledge to respect it. Franklin Pierce of NH being elected in 1852 further sealed the issue of the compromise.

Manifest Destiny

Stephen F Austin

Republic of Texas

Sir Francis Drake

"Oregon Fever"

James K Polk

John Slidell

Nicholas P. Trist
Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo
Zachary Taylor
“popular sovereignty”
“49ers”
Franklin Pierce